

1

Capability

FASTER, BUT JAGGED

- Industry produced over 90% of notable frontier models; systems reached human baselines in PhD science, multimodal reasoning and competition math.
- SWE-bench Verified rose from 60% to near the human baseline, while OSWorld agents jumped from 12% to about 66% success.
- The frontier remains uneven: the best model reads analog clocks correctly only 50.1%, and household robots succeed on just 12% of tasks.

4

Responsibility

GOVERNANCE LAGS

- Documented AI incidents rose from 233 in 2024 to 362; responsible-AI reporting remains much spottier than capability reporting.
- Safety interventions can trade off with accuracy, so progress cannot be summarized by a single benchmark.
- Environmental costs are rising: AI data-center capacity reached 29.6 GW and Grok 4 training emitted 72,816 tCO2e.

2

Global landscape

POWER IS CONCENTRATED

- The U.S.-China model gap effectively closed; as of March 2026, Anthropic's lead was only 2.7%.
- The U.S. leads top models and high-impact patents; China leads publications, citations, patent volume and industrial robot installations.
- The U.S. hosts 5,427 data centers, while TSMC fabricates almost every leading AI chip—concentrating infrastructure risk.

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Science & society

HIGH VALUE, THIN EVIDENCE

- AI beats human chemists on ChemBench, but remains below 20% on astrophysics replication and 33% on Earth-observation questions.
- Ambient clinical scribes cut note-taking time by up to 83%, yet only 5% of 500+ reviewed clinical AI studies used real clinical data.
- Over 80% of U.S. high-school and college students use AI, but only 6% of teachers say school AI policies are clear.

3

Economy & work

ADOPTION MEETS DISRUPTION

- Organizational AI adoption reached 88%; generative AI reached 53% population adoption within three years.
- U.S. private AI investment hit \$285.9B versus China's \$12.4B, alongside 1,953 newly funded U.S. AI companies.
- Measured productivity gains reach 14-26%, yet employment for U.S. developers aged 22-25 fell nearly 20% from 2024.

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Policy & trust

SOVEREIGNTY + TRUST GAP

- National AI strategies and state-backed supercomputing are expanding, while model production remains concentrated in the U.S. and China.
- Open source broadens participation: contributions outside the U.S., China and Europe now approach U.S. activity on GitHub.
- Experts and the public diverge sharply on jobs—73% versus 23% expect positive impact; U.S. trust in government regulation is only 31%.

AI INDEX 2026

AI Index Report 2026

Stanford HAI | Global Evidence on AI Development and Impact

AI capabilities and adoption accelerated in 2025, but safety, institutions, education and physical-world reliability are adapting more slowly—creating a powerful yet jagged global transition.

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